a humorous note, I remember also thinking that only the spine of steel of a small man like Shamir could stand up to the pressures that were exerted on him! The test of time shows that Shamir was certainly right in opposing the IDF's intervention in the war.

In 1955, Isser Harel recruited Yitzhak Shamir to the Mossad. Isser, with Prime Minister Ben-Gurion's approval, decided to recruit the best of the underground movements' members to the Mossad. I think that there are three reasons that can explain the rationale behind this decision:

1. To heal the wounds of the political and social rifts that existed on the eve of the establishment of the state and its early years
2. To make use of human resources with knowledge, experience and many successes in clandestine activity in the years prior to the establishment of the state
3. To integrate these good people into the state systems rather than to leave them outside the state as rejects

In the Mossad, Yitzhak commanded a special unit of Jewish combatants operating completely undercover in target countries. The Intelligence Corps operated a parallel unit at the time. Meir Amit, who replaced Isser as head of the Mossad, brought the unit from MI to the Mossad and united it with the Mossad unit under Shamir's command. The unification of the two units was not a simple process, and it is doubtful whether the scars from it ever healed completely. Regrettably, Shamir retired from the Mossad in 1965 as a result of this process.

Isser and Shamir had a very close relationship. After all, they spoke to one another at eye level! The military culture that prevailed in the Mossad after Isser's departure did not suit Shamir.

I used to meet with Shamir even after his retirement. He was always busy, in his infinite enthusiasm, with the need—which he defined as existential—to bring another million Jews, and another million, to Israel. I believe that today as well, the Israeli government should make this a high priority on the national agenda.

In conclusion, I can only quote from the book of Job, chapter 12, verse 12: "With aged men is wisdom, and in length of days understanding."